

{PROXY}Maze'26

Most Popular Project Award - Rules

Stage 3 community vote. Winner announced on Grand Final day, July 12.

Torch Labs Software | Grand Final: July 12, 2026

1. Award Purpose

The Most Popular Project Award recognises the team whose elevator pitch video receives the highest verified public engagement during the official voting period.

This award is separate from the main judging process. It is decided entirely by social media engagement on the official Torch Labs posts, not by the panel of judges.

Only videos published by the official Torch Labs and {PROXY}Maze'26 social media accounts will count toward this award. Engagement on videos uploaded by participants to their own accounts does not count unless the organizers explicitly state otherwise.

2. Eligible Videos

Only the 10 shortlisted teams that submitted a video by the June 21 deadline are eligible for this award.

Each team's video will be published by Torch Labs across the official social media accounts. All 10 videos will go live at the same time so that every team has an equal window to collect engagement.

3. Voting Period

The official voting period will be announced by the organizers after all videos have been published. Only engagement received during this window will count toward the final score.

- Engagement received before the voting period opens will not be counted.
- Engagement received after the voting period closes will not be counted.
- The organizers will announce the exact start and end dates on the official channels.

4. Scoring Method

$$\text{Final Score} = \text{Total Likes} + (\text{Total Shares} \times 3)$$

Shares are weighted three times higher than likes because a share actively distributes the video to a new audience, while a like is a passive reaction. A team with fewer likes but more shares may outscore a team with more likes.

Signal	Weight	Notes
Likes	×1	Each like on the official post counts as 1 point.
Shares	×3	Each share on the official post counts as 3 points.
Comments	Not counted	Comments do not affect the score.
Views	Tiebreaker only	Used only if two or more teams have the same final score.

Example: a team with 500 likes and 80 shares scores $500 + (80 \times 3) = 740$ points. A team with 700 likes and 10 shares scores $700 + (10 \times 3) = 730$ points. The first team wins despite having fewer likes.

5. Platforms and What Is Counted

The organizers will confirm which platforms are included before the voting period opens. The expected platforms are listed below. Only engagement from official Torch Labs posts on these platforms will be counted.

Platform	What is counted
Instagram	Likes and shares on the official Torch Labs post.
Facebook	Likes, reactions, and shares on the official post.
LinkedIn	Likes, reactions, and reposts on the official post.
TikTok	Likes and shares on the official post.
X / Twitter	Likes and retweets on the official post.
YouTube Shorts	Likes on the official video.

6. Fair Promotion Is Allowed

Teams are allowed and encouraged to promote their video through normal, organic methods. Getting your network to engage with the official post is part of the competition.

Allowed promotion methods include:

- Sharing the official Torch Labs post with friends, classmates, and personal networks.
- Posting the official video link on your own social media accounts.
- Asking people directly to like and share the official post.
- Sharing the post in university groups, community groups, or industry communities where allowed by those communities.
- Sending the link through messaging apps and group chats.

7. Artificial Engagement Is Not Allowed

Teams are not allowed to use any artificial, automated, or paid methods to inflate their engagement score. The following are strictly prohibited:

- Fake likes or fake reactions from any source.
- Bot engagement or automated scripts.
- Paid engagement farms or purchased likes and shares.
- Mass fake accounts used for voting.
- Proxy-based or VPN-based engagement manipulation.
- Coordinated spam sharing designed to artificially inflate reach.
- Any method that generates engagement without genuine human action.

Any team found using artificial engagement methods will be disqualified from the Most Popular Project Award. The organizers reserve the right to review and reject any engagement that appears suspicious, automated, or manipulated.

8. Paid Promotion Is Not Allowed

Teams are not allowed to run paid advertisements, boosted posts, influencer promotions, or any paid social media campaigns for their project video.

This rule exists to keep the award fair for all teams regardless of budget. If the organizers choose to boost any videos, all eligible teams will be boosted equally under the same conditions and budget.

9. Official Count and Final Decision

The organizers will record the final likes and shares at the end of the voting period. The count taken by the organizers at the close of the window is final.

Platform analytics, exported reports, or screenshots may be used as supporting evidence for the final numbers. The organizers' decision regarding the final count is not subject to appeal.

10. Tie-Breaker Rule

If two or more teams finish with the same final score, the winner is selected using the following tie-breakers in order:

1. Higher number of shares.
 2. Higher number of likes.
 3. Higher number of video views on the official post.
 4. Final decision by the organizers.
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11. Organizer Rights

Torch Labs reserves the right to:

- Review, verify, adjust, or reject any engagement that appears suspicious, fake, or manipulated.
- Disqualify any team from this award for violating the rules above.
- Amend the rules or voting period with reasonable notice on the official channels.
- Make the final decision on the winner in the event of any dispute.

The organizers' decision on all matters relating to the Most Popular Project Award is final.

Questions

Contact the organising team for any questions about the award rules, eligible promotion methods, or the voting period. All rule clarifications will be communicated through the official channels before the voting period opens.
